time, bewildered when TV coverage of the Test was interrupted by horseracing.

I queued for his autograph as a child and grew up quickly because of his patronage. He was hugely influential, supporting me financially in grade cricket in Perth during a gap year, where the wickets were slow and low, and I didn't even appear to merit the traditional verbal abuse from Aussie bowlers.

Sometimes, in sport, the circle of life accelerates. Goochy saw something in me, drove me hard, but looked after my wider welfare. Like my mum, he urged me to go to university instead of prematurely committing myself to full-time cricket. His rationale was based on bitter knowledge; he had seen too many young players released in their early twenties with nothing to fall back upon.

He didn't want me to make a common mistake. I resisted, in part due to the beliefs and disciplines he had instilled in me from the outset. I worked hard with him, ritually and regularly. I would chop wood at his house with Swampy, my housemate and fellow hopeful Mark Pettini, before training sessions designed to test us physically and mentally.

He would send us on long early morning runs and pedal beside us, offering admonishment and encouragement. He would bombard us with bouncers for half an hour in the nets before tiredness thankfully took a toll. Sessions on the outfield at Essex were demanding: ten shuttle runs, face four balls, and then do another six shuttles. He would make us run backwards at speed and stand over us as we sweated through a series of burpees and press-ups.

He was a distinctive cross between an army PTI and a solicitous housemaster. Once the work was complete, he wanted us to clear our minds, relax and release. I was eager for knowledge, and he warned against self-reproach when I disappointed myself. It was a significant message, delivered simply and illustrated by personal experience.

He confided that his method of finding mental equilibrium on losing his wicket was to sit with his pads still on. He would have a cup of tea and answer his mail. This was before the internet and smart phones, the days when pen and paper weren't museum pieces. That triggered my imagination; how could he be so phlegmatic? What was behind his acceptance of fate?